

may carry a sheaf of love letters along to prove the point. Similarly, in cases of international child abduction, Indian judges may not see anything amiss in a man removing his child from the legal custody of his wife in a foreign country and leaving him/her to the care of his parents in India: the latter would appear eminently appropriate caretakers.

Similarly, short of blatant extortion, the mercenary aspect of Indian marriage is not something that ipso facto impugns the relationship. On the contrary, the extravagant exchange of marriage gifts, asymmetrical as it usually is, is seen as a means to cement the marital relationship and the relations of intermarrying families. The poor Haryana farmer, who is obliged to buy a wife from Andhra Pradesh or Bangladesh, is more to be pitied than blamed if this is the only way he can acquire a woman to work on his farm or bear him children. Public sympathy may be more with a childless couple than with a surrogate mother. And it would be hard to imagine an ayah claiming custody of her deceased employer's children on the grounds that she had been their most constant care-giver; or the servant, personal trainer or personal physician becoming a legal heir, will or no will.

In India, we are wont to see the future of the



Photo Illustration by BANDEEP SINGH

## THE POOR HARYANA FARMER WHO IS OBLIGED TO BUY A WIFE FROM ANDHRA PRADESH OR BANGLADESH IS MORE TO BE PITIED THAN BLAMED.

Indian family in the mirror of the West and mostly shudder at the thought. We see marital instability there, where actually romance and marriage are put at the centre of family life. We see a lack of family solidarity when children leave home the moment they begin to earn, or when an elderly person moves into a retirement home, though the persons concerned may take pride in their assertion of independence or in their ability to pay for the personal services they need. And we view with horror the conduct of some people who choose to

commit their partners to an institution as the solution to a situation of massive dependency.

We need to realise that these expressions of the contemporary Western dialectic of commerce and love are located within a particular socio-cultural milieu. They are not necessarily visions of the global future. But to understand where the Indian family is heading, we need to attend more respectfully to the dynamics of our own society in its own terms. Alas, we are habitually far too fascinated with the Other to do so. ■



*Patricia Uberoi is a sociologist and an honorary fellow at the Institute of Chinese Studies, Centre for the Study of Developing Societies, Delhi.*

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